Advanced & Post Reading Material (APRM)
EPP- II, 2025-26 GLA U, Mathura
Module-I (Verbal Skills)
Conditionals

Conditional sentences consist of a conditional clause and a main clause:

1- [conditional clause] ***If*** *a lot of people come,* [main clause] *we'll have to get extra chairs.*

2- [conditional clause] ***Unless*** *you book weeks in advance,* [main clause] *you won't get a flight.*

The verb in the conditional clause reflects the speaker's point of view on whether the imagined situation is likely or impossible:

1-*If you* ***win*** *the next match,* ***will*** *you be in the semi-final?* (present simple + *will* indicates the speaker thinks winning the match is possible or likely)

2-*If I* ***won*** *a million pounds, I* ***would give*** *this job up tomorrow!* (past simple + *would* indicates the speaker thinks winning a million pounds is not likely to happen)

3-*If we* ***had won*** *the competition, we* ***would have had*** *a free trip to Moscow.* (past perfect + *would have* refers to an impossible condition – the event did not happen)

Order of clauses:

Conditional clauses usually come before main clauses, but they may also come after them:
1-***If you see Dora****, will you give her a message?* (conditional clause first; a comma is normally used in writing)

2-*I'll go to Bristol tomorrow* ***if the weather is good****.* (conditional clause second; a comma is not normally used in writing)

Verb forms in the conditional clause

The verb in the conditional clause may be in the simple form or the continuous form, depending on the meaning:

1-*If you* ***owe*** *money, you must pay it back immediately.* (present simple)

2-*If you're* ***feeling*** *hungry, we can go and get something to eat.* (present continuous)

3-*If he* ***had*** *time, he always called in to see us.* (past simple)

4-*If they* ***were working****, we always tried not to disturb them.* (past continuous)

Conditions: Imagined vs Real:

Imagined situations

Conditional sentences consider imagined or uncertain situations and the possible results of these situations. The most common types of conditional sentences involve *if*:
[imagined situation] ***If*** *I get the job in Milan,* [result] *I'll be pretty happy.*
[outcome]*We'll have the party in the garden* [imagined situation]***as long as*** *it doesn't rain.* (Or … *if it doesn't rain*. or … *on condition that it doesn't rain*.)

Imagined conditions:

There are different types of conditions. Some are possible or likely, others are unlikely, and others are impossible:
1-***If the weather improves****, we'll go for a walk.* (It is possible or likely that the weather will improve.)
2-***If the weather improved****, we could go for a walk.* (It is not likely that the weather will improve.)
3-***If the weather had improved****, we could have gone for a walk.* (The weather did not improve – fine weather is therefore an impossible condition.)

These types of conditions are used in three types of sentences, called first, second and third conditional sentences.

Imagined conditions: the first conditional

We use the first conditional to talk about the result of an imagined future situation, when we believe the imagined situation is quite likely:

[imagined future situation] *If the taxi doesn't come soon,* [future result] *I'll drive you myself.*

First conditional: form

conditional clause	main clause
if + present simple	modal verb with future meaning (*shall/should/will/would/can/could/may/might*)
*If he **gets** a job in Liverpool,*	*he**'ll** have to get up early. It's a long drive.*
*If Sheila **rings**,*	*I **might ask** her to come over for dinner.*

Warning:
We use the modal verb in the main clause, not in the conditional clause.
*If a lawyer **reads** the document, we **will see** if we've missed anything important.*

Not: If a lawyer will read the document…

Imagined conditions: the second conditional

We use the second conditional to talk about the possible result of an imagined situation in the present or future.

*If people **complained**,*
*things **would** change.* (People don't complain at the moment.)

Second conditional: form

conditional clause	main clause
if + past simple	modal verb with future-in-the-past meaning (*should/would/might/could*)
*If you **asked** her nicely,*	*she **would** say yes, I'm sure.*

We use a past form in the conditional clause to indicate a distance from reality, rather than indicating past time.

Warning: We use *would* in the main clause, not in the conditional clause:

*If you **decided** to take the exam, you would have to register by 31 March.*

Not: If you would decide to take the exam …

First and second conditional compared

When we use the first conditional, we think the imagined situation is more likely to happen than when we use the second conditionals

Compare

First conditional	Second conditional
*If the flight**'s** late, we**'ll miss** our connection.* (it's possible or likely that the flight will be late)	*If there **were** more buses, we **would leave** the car at home.* (it is unlikely that there will be more buses)
*I**'ll come** and give a hand if you **need** help moving your stuff.* (it is possible or likely that you will need help)	*He **would buy** a flat if he **had** the money for a deposit.* (it is unlikely that he will have the money)

Imagined conditions: the third conditional

We use the third conditional when we imagine a different past, where something did or did not happen, and we imagine a different result:

1-*If I **had played** better, I **would have won**.* (I didn't play well and I didn't win.)

2-*It **would have been** easier if George **had brought** his own car.* (George didn't bring his own car, so the situation was difficult.)

3-*If the dog **hadn't barked**, we **wouldn't have known** there was someone in the garden.* (The dog barked, so we knew there was someone in the garden.)

Third conditional: form

conditional clause	main clause
if + past perfect	modal verb with future-in-the-past meaning (*should/would/might/could*) + *have* + *-ed* form
*If they **had left** earlier,*	*they **would have arrived** on time.*

Warning:

We use *would have* + *-ed* in the main clause, not in the conditional clause:

*If he **had stayed** in the same room as Dave, it **would have been** a disaster.*

Not: If he would have stayed … it would have been a disaster.

Real conditionals

Some conditions seem more real to us than others. Real conditionals refer to things that are true, that have happened, or are very likely to happen:

1-*If you park here, they clamp your wheels.* (It is always true that they clamp your wheels if, or every time, you park here.)

2-*If I can't sleep, I listen to the radio.* (it is often true that I can't sleep, so I listen to the radio)

In real conditional sentences, we can use the present simple or present continuous in both clauses for present situations, and the past simple or past continuous in both clauses for past situations. We can use these in various different combinations.

Present simple + present simple

1-*If the weather **is** fine, we **eat** outside on the terrace.* (Every time this happens, this is what we do.)

Present continuous + present simple

1-*If the kids **are enjoying** themselves, we just **let** them go on playing till they're ready for bed.* (Every time this happens, this is what we do.)

Present continuous + present continuous

1-*If the economy **is growing** by 6%, then **it is growing** too fast.* (If it is true that the economy is growing by 6%, then it is true that it is growing too fast.)

Past simple + past simple

1-*If my father **had** a day off, we always **went** to see my granddad.* (Every time that happened in the past, that is what we did.)

Past simple + past continuous

*Kevin always **came** in to say hello if he **was going** past our house.* (Every time he was going past our house, that is what he did.)

We can also use modal verbs in the main clause:

1-*If we go out, we **can** usually **get** a babysitter.* (Every time we go out, it is usually possible to get a babysitter.)

2-*If we wanted someone to fix something, we **would ask** our neighbour. He was always ready to help.* (Every time we wanted someone, we would ask our neighbour.)

Types of conditional: summary

The table shows how the main types of conditionals relate to one another.

true	likely/possible	less likely/less possible	impossible
real	first	second	third
*If it **snows**, we **get** our skis out.* (We do this every time it snows.)	*If she **gets** the job, we'**ll** celebrate.* (It is possible or likely she will get the job.)	*If we **had** more students, we would **run** the course.* (It is less likely or unlikely that we will get more students.)	*If the rent. **had been** lower, I would **have taken** the flat.* (The rent was not low enough.)

If* + *should

We can use *if* with *should* to refer to events which might happen by chance or by accident:

***If** you **should** bump into Carol, can you tell her I'm looking for her?* (If by chance you bump into Carol.)

1-***If** the government **should ever find itself in this situation again, it is to be hoped it would act more quickly.***

Conditional clauses with *will* or *would:*

Will and *would* can be used in conditional clauses, either with the meaning of 'being willing to do something', or to refer to later results:

1-***If*** Clare ***will*** meet us at the airport, it will save us a lot of time. (if Clare is willing to meet us)

2-***If*** you ***would*** all stop shouting, I will try and explain the situation!
3-***If*** it ***will*** make you happy, I'll stay at home tonight. (If it is true that you will be happy as a result, I'll stay at home tonight.)

We sometimes stress the will or would, especially if we doubt that the result will be the one mentioned:
***If** it really **would** save the planet, I'd stop using my car tomorrow.* (If it really is true that the planet would be saved as a result, I would stop using my car, but I doubt it is true.)

Mixed conditionals

Often, things that did or did not happen in the past have results which continue or are still important in the present. We can emphasize this by using if with a past perfect verb and would in the main clause. If I hadn't met Charles, I wouldn't be here now. (I met Charles so I'm here now.) She wouldn't still be working for us if we hadn't given her a pay rise. (We gave her a pay-rise, so she is still working for us now.)

Unless

Conditional clauses can begin with *unless*. *Unless* means something similar to 'if … not' or 'except if'.

The verb forms in the examples are similar to sentences with *if*: we use the present simple in the *unless* clause and *shall, should, will, would, can, could, may* or *might* in the main clause:

***Unless** I **phone** you, you **can** assume the trains on time.* (If I do not phone you /except if I phone you, you can assume the train is on time.)

*We'll have to cancel the show **unless** we **sell** more tickets at the last minute.* (We'll have to cancel the show if we do not sell more tickets/except if we sell more tickets at the last minute.)

Warning:

We don't use *unless* for impossible conditions:

***If** the government had **not** raised food prices, there would not have been so many protests.*

Not: Unless the government had raised food prices …

Warning:

We don't use *unless* and *if* together:

*We'll go to the coast tomorrow **unless** it rains.*

Not: We'll go to the coast tomorrow unless if it rains.

We use the conjunction *unless* to mean 'except if'. The clause which follows *unless* is a subordinate clause (sc): it needs a main clause (mc) to make a complete sentence.

When *unless* comes before the main clause, we use a comma:

[SC] ***Unless** it rains,* [MC]*we'll go for a picnic by the river tomorrow.* (We'll go for a picnic by the river tomorrow if it doesn't rain.)

When the main clause comes first, we don't need a comma:

[MC] They won't come ***unless*** [SC] you invite them.
Unless is a conditional word (like if), so we don't use will or would in the subordinate clause:
Unless I hear from you, I'll see you at two o'clock.
Not: ***Unless*** I'll hear from you …
Unless and if … not
Unless and if … not both mean 'except if':

We could eat at Siam Smile ***unless*** they're closed on a Monday. (or, we could eat at Siam Smile if they're not closed on a Monday.)
I'll make dinner ***unless*** somebody else wants to. (or, I'll make dinner if nobody else wants to.)
Can you turn the radio off ***unless*** you're listening to it? (or can you turn the radio off if you're not listening to it?)

We don't use *unless* for things that we know to be true:
You won't be able to get a ticket for the match *unless* you're prepared to pay a lot of money for it. (The speaker doesn't know if you're prepared to pay a lot of money for a ticket.)

I don't know what we would have done if we hadn't seen you. (We did see you.)
Not: I don't know what we would have done *unless* we'd seen you.

Typical errors
We don't use it unless we mean if:
Pete will drive if Alex can't.
Not: Pete will drive unless Alex can't.
We don't use will or would in the clause after unless:
Unless you pay now, we can't guarantee you a ticket.
Not: Unless you'll pay now …